6 Everyday use and help

FULL

09. Troubleshooting: when something does not work

Quick version

No time to read it all? This is the short version. The full guide is below.

- How to fix problems: a method first, then common problems with the check and the fix for each.
- Stay calm and change nothing yet. Write down what you were doing.
- Run the checklist (menu `5`). Fix the first FAIL line, then run it again.
- If the install stopped, menu `1` again carries on from there.
- Change one thing, test, and write down what you changed.
- Still stuck after 20 minutes? Menu `H` makes a help file (no passwords in it). Your backups in `backups/` mean you can always go back.
- Stop and ask someone you trust if a battery looks swollen, anything smells hot or burnt, or water has touched anything electrical.

Problems are normal. This page gives you a **method**, then a list of common problems with the exact check and fix for each.

The method (follow it in order)

1. **Stay calm. Change nothing yet.** Write down what you were doing and what you expected.

2. **Run the checklist:** menu `5` (or `bash garden.sh check`). It lists what is working and what is not, and what to do. Fix the **first FAIL** line, then run it again. If the INSTALL stopped: `logs/install-progress.txt` shows the step it stopped at; menu `1` again carries on from there.
3. **Read the error.** The last 5 lines usually say the cause.
4. **Look at the logs:** - Website: `docker compose logs --tail 40 site` - Database: `docker compose logs --tail 40 db` - Caddy: `sudo journalctl -u caddy -n 40 --no-pager` - No-IP: `sudo journalctl -u noip-duc -n 20 --no-pager`
5. **Change one thing**, test, and write down what you changed.
6. **Still stuck after 20 minutes?** Menu `H` makes a help file in `help/` (no passwords in it). Read it, then paste it into Gemini (see 16) or show it to someone you trust.
7. **Stuck and worried you broke something?** Your backups are in `backups/`. You can always go back.

Quick fixes you can always try

Try	Command
Start everything that should be running	menu `2` (or `docker compose up -d`)
The install stopped half way	menu `1` again: it shows the steps done and carries on
The build "hangs" for minutes	On an old laptop the Rust build is slow. If text still appears now and then, it is working.
"Cannot connect to the Docker daemon" right after install	Log out and back in once (the docker group). The menu uses sudo until then.
Restart just the website	`docker compose restart site`
Restart the laptop (fixes many things)	`sudo reboot`
See what is using the disk	`docker system df` and `df -h /`

Try	Command
Free space safely	`bash garden.sh cleanup` (menu `M`, `14`, `5`): only the garden's old versions, older than 7 days; asks first; never your data folders

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Ubuntu and the laptop

Problem	Check	Fix
Laptop will not start from the USB	Boot menu key (guide 01, Part C)	Try another USB port; remake the stick (Rufus DD mode); set USB first in the BIOS
Black screen after install	Did it get past the login?	Boot with `nomodeset` (guide 01 table), then install the right graphics driver
No Wi-Fi	`ip a` shows a Wi-Fi line?	Plug in a cable; search the menu for **Additional Drivers**
Everything is very slow	`htop` (press `q` to leave)	Close the browser; check `free -h` for swap; consider Xubuntu and an SSD
Laptop is very hot	Is the lid shut?	Open it a little; put it on a stand; clean the vents
Screen goes to sleep or laptop suspends	`systemctl status sleep.target`	Run `lab/01-prepare-ubuntu.sh` again and restart
`sudo` says "not in the sudoers file"	The first user you made should be allowed	Ask someone you trust who knows Linux; do not try to fix this alone

Docker

Problem	Check	Fix
`permission denied ... docker.sock`	`groups` shows `docker`?	Log out and in again (or reboot)

Problem	Check	Fix
`docker: command not found`	`docker --version`	Run `lab/02-install-docker.sh`
Build stops: "killed" or "out of memory"	`free -h`, then `dmesg --level=err`	Add swap (`lab/01-prepare-ubuntu.sh`), close other programs, build again
Build is very slow	Normal on old laptops	Wait; the first build takes 15 to 45 minutes (up to an hour on a very old laptop or a Pi)
Port is already in use	`sudo ss -ltnp` (look for :8030)	Stop the other program, or change the port in `docker-compose.yml`
Disk full	`df -h /`	`bash garden.sh cleanup`; delete old files in `backups/` after copying them

The garden website

Problem	Check	Fix
`localhost:8030` does not load	`docker ps` lists `garden-site`?	`docker compose up -d`; read `docker compose logs site`
`{"status":"error"}` on healthz	Database up? `docker compose ps`	`docker compose restart db` then `restart site`
Cannot log in	Did you set a password?	Menu `U`, then `5`
"Too many tries"	5 wrong tries lock you out	Wait 15 minutes
Photos will not upload	`ls -ld local/images`	`chmod -R a+rwX local/images`
No password email arrives	Is email set up?	Menu `8` Settings, `3`, and send the test email; check spam

Problem	Check	Fix
Page is empty	You have no plants yet	Add some in `/streamlit/`, or restore a backup
Gallery error in the log about `tags_cache.csv`	Do you have gallery photos?	Normal with no photos
Site is down after a reboot	`docker ps`	Docker starts it again by itself (it is set to). If you stopped it with menu `3`, it stays stopped: menu `2` starts it

The internet side (Caddy, Apache, No-IP, router)

Problem	Check	Fix
Name does not resolve	`getent hosts YOUR-NAME.ddns.net`	`sudo systemctl status noip-duc`; check the key; confirm the free name on noip.com (No-IP emails you a link every 30 days: click **Confirm**)
Name shows the wrong address	Compare with `curl -s https://api.ipify.org`	Wait 5 to 10 minutes; make sure only ONE updater is running for that name
Works at home, not on a phone	Test with Wi-Fi off	Router port forwarding for 80 and 443 (guide 04, Part D); some routers cannot reach their own name from inside, which is normal
Padlock or certificate error	`sudo journalctl -u caddy -n 50`	Ports 80 and 443 must reach the laptop from outside; the name must resolve first
502 Bad Gateway	`curl http://127.0.0.1:8030/healthz`	The website is down: `docker compose up -d`

Problem	Check	Fix
Caddy will not start	`sudo caddy validate --config /etc/caddy/Caddyfile`	Fix the line it names
"Address already in use" for Caddy or Apache	`sudo ss -ltnp` (look for :80 and :443)	Only Caddy may use 80 and 443. Apache must be on 127.0.0.1:8081 (`lab/06-install-apache-learn.sh`)
Router says CGNAT or a `100.64.x.x` address	Compare router WAN address with `ipify`	Hosting from home is not possible; use Tailscale for private access

An old or wrong padlock certificate

What you see: the browser says "Your connection is not private", or that the certificate has expired or is not valid for this name.

Why: Caddy (the front door) gets a new certificate by itself, about every two months. It can only do that while your web name points to your home and ports 80 and 443 reach the garden computer. If one of those stops, the old certificate runs out.

Fix it, in this order: 1. Run the checklist: menu `5`. 2. Is your web name pointing home? `sudo systemctl status noip-duc` should say **active (running)**. If not: menu `K`, then `N`, and paste your No-IP key again. 3. Is the router still sending ports 80 and 443 to the garden computer's address? (Guide 04, Part D. If the address changed: guide 14.) 4. Ask Caddy why: `sudo journalctl -u caddy -n 50`. Read the lines with "error". 5. Set the front door again: menu `M`, then `1`, then `3` (your real web name). It rewrites the settings, checks them and restarts Caddy, which then gets a new certificate (up to a minute). 6. In the browser, reload the page with **Ctrl+F5**.

A practice name (ending in `.test`) always shows a warning. That one is expected. Caddy's own page: https://caddyserver.com/docs/automatic-https.

Home Assistant, Govee, n8n, ESPHome

Problem	Check	Fix
Home Assistant page is blank	`docker logs --tail 30 homeassistant`	Wait a few minutes after first start
Govee light not found	Is **LAN Control** on in the Govee app? Same Wi-Fi network?	Turn it on; put the light and the laptop on the same network
n8n email test fails	Credential test message	App password wrong, or 2-Step Verification off; try port 587
ESP32 not seen by the laptop	`lsusb` or the ESPHome device list	Use a data USB cable; hold BOOT while connecting
Sensor values jump around	Loose wire	Re-seat wires; use GPIO34

Safety problems: stop and ask

Stop and ask someone you trust before you go on if: - A battery looks swollen, or anything smells hot or burnt. - Water has touched anything electrical. - You see logins or strange requests in the Caddy log that you do not recognise, repeated for hours (a few bots are normal). - You pasted a password somewhere by mistake. Change that password first (menu `U`, `5` for your garden password; menu `K` for a key), then delete what you pasted, if you can.

Next: 10 The plan